The Book of Leviticus Show

By Christopher Durang

INTRODUCTION

*(Solemnly) Leviticus 19:18 "Thou shalt love they neighbor as thyself." But that's only one nugget of wisdom found in the Bible. There's so much more about how humanity must live to be right with God and one another. But, really, who reads anymore? *According to the National Literacy Institute, 21% of adults in the US are illiterate and 54% read below the 6th grade level. Maybe there should be a TV show (or at least a Podcast, Tick Tock or You Tube video series) to keep us on track . . .*

(Announcer's voice) Welcome to Channel 61 in Wheeling, West Virginia! If you've ever wondered what would happen if the FCC, the Good Book, and a clearance-sale camcorder teamed up for a revival meeting in a roadside motel, you've found the right channel! Broadcasting live -- the premiere episode of "The Book of Leviticus Show!"

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(A rundown motel room in West Virginia. A bed with an elderly Grandma asleep on it. An empty bird cage. Suitcases around, opened, not quite unpacked. Lettie Lu is wandering around with lots of nervous energy. Her husband Tommy is running the camera)

LETTIE LU: *(to the camera)* Are we on the air? Hello there. Can you hear me? If you can't hear me, call 556- 421, and ask for Lettie Lu in Room 12, and then I'll talk up. This here is our first show, and so I don't know if I need to shout.

And this is Momma. *(Grandma snores obnoxiously)* Momma is eighty-three years old and she brought me up all her life in West Virginia and she's a good woman. I'm Lettie Lu and this is the first *Book of Leviticus Show* installment. *(sing a few lines from a hymn)*

Now I was minding my business back in Tommy's and my house in West Virginia. The children had growed up, one of them is a country Western star, one of them is a teller in a bank. Jimmy, he hasn't found himself yet, he don't do nothing. But we were havin' our quiet life when God set our house on fire. Well, it wasn't God really, it was Momma; leastwise, we think it was Momma, she denies it, but who else was up cookin' at two in the morning, not me or Tommy, we wuz asleep.

But our house burned to the ground, all of it; and we wuz real bitter. We slept in the truck for a couple of nights, but then I said to Tommy, "What are we complainin' about, we got our lives. God gave us our lives, and we have got to be grateful."

And then we took the Bible out of the glove compartment, and I said, "Tommy, this is God's word, and it will comfort us." *(picks up the Bible and shows the camera)* You know, you can open up the Bible to any old page and it will have a message for you.

(chooses a section at random) Like here, in the Book of Numbers: *(reads with difficulty)* "And the names of the men are these: of the tribes of Judah, Caleb the son of Jephunneh. And of the tribe of of Simeon, Shemeul, the son of Annihud. . . " Well, this here don't mean a thing!

But then we read that lovely passage about the Lord is thy shepherd and the green pastures . . . and we had some money in the bank, so we thought we'd just come on over to this motel, where the owner is a good Christian woman and her daughter with the harelip, but really it doesn't look bad if you don't look at it. And then Tommy said, "Lettie, read another passage from the Bible."

And then I turned to the Book of Leviticus. *(reads with great importance)* "And the man that committeth adultery with another man's wife, even he that committeth adultery with his neighbor's wife, the adulterer and the adulteress shall surely be put to death."

Well, that made a lot of sense to us because in all our years of marriage, and I married Tommy when I was fourteen or something just like Loretta Lynn did 'ceptin' I don't sing none; well, in all that time, Tommy and I has never been unfaithful to one another because

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we believe in God and religion and marriage. And I got to thinkin' about how people say they believe in the Bible but they don't follow through and do nothin' about it.

(flips through the Bible again) Oh yeah. This is from the same page as the thing about adultery. *(reads)* "And if a man also lie with mankind, as he lieth with a woman, both of them have committed an abomination, they shall surely be put to death." *(slams the Bible shut)*

Well, we checked with the minister about the wordin' just to make sure we understood, but what we thought was true ***was*** true: This is about *(whispers)* homo[sexuals]! And notice that God says ***surely*** someone will put them to death. He just ***presumes*** somebody's gonna do it for him!

We've gotten mighty far from followin' God's commands.

So what we done is, we went to Sally Bowden's house, and she's got herself two strappin' big sons, Big Jake and Big Harry, and we went into town and Big Jake and Big Harry went out and they captured an adulteress and a homo[sexual] for us, and they tied 'em up and brung 'em here. I mean, they're here right now. *(Lettie Lu moves a screen. Behind it, tied up on the floor and with gags in their mouths, are a Woman and a Man)* See? I kept 'em behind the screen to add to the suspense. I hope you like our show.

So now we're going to follow the teachings of God in the Book of Leviticus. Wake up, Momma. *(goes over to Grandma, tries to wake her; to Grandma)* Momma. God, I hope she's not dead. *(Grandma snorts)* Oh, there she goes. You havin' a dream, Momma?

GRANDMA: Where's my teeth?

LETTIE LU: Well, did you go to sleep with them in your mouth, or did you take them out first?

GRANDMA: I don't know where they are.

LETTIE LU: We know that, Momma. We are on television, and nobody out there wants to hear about your teeth.

GRANDMA: I had a dream about pancakes.

LETTIE LU: Pancakes? Oh, Momma, you're irritatin' everybody. *(gets a gun from somewhere easy)* Old age is a terrible thing. *(gets in a position, aims at the two people on the floor. Aims,*

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but maybe looks the other way; she's not bloodthirsty, just doing her best to follow the Bible) Pay attention now, Momma, we're gonna kill 'em. *(Grandma puts her fingers in her ears)* In the name of God's will, you shall ***surely*** be put to death. *(fires the gun twice)*

GRANDMA: Do we know these people?

LETTIE LU: *(annoyed to explain it again)* We met 'em in town, Momma, Jake and Harry tied 'em up, and I read in the Bible that God wanted somebody to kill 'em.

GRANDMA: *(understanding)* Oh.

LETTIE LU: *(to camera)* Well, I'm gonna sign off now. Read your bible, follow everything it says. And next week, we're gonna do the part from the Book of Leviticus about how to sacrifice turtle doves to please God.

GRANDMA: Where we gonna get a turtle dove?

LETTIE LU: I don't know. Maybe Woolworths'll have one of those 98 cents parakeets and then I'll kill that.

GRANDMA: Kill the parakeet?

LETTIE LU: That's what it says in the Bible. God, you can't follow anything! It's amazing I grew up to be as smart as I am. *(to camera)* Good-bye, all! God bless you! Tune in next week for more readings from the Book of Leviticus Show! *(waves at the camera. So does Grandma)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Christopher Durang
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AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
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****Introduction source data***
https://www.thenationalliteracyinstitute.com/2024-2025-literacy-statistics

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